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Butch Miles

Charles "Butch" Miles is a well known figure on the national and international jazz scene. Born on July 4, 1944, he grew up in Charlestown, West Virginia. He took to the drums early on and became one of the youngest drummers to ever drive the Count Basie band. Butch has supported such stellar artists as Tony Bennett, Joe Williams, Lena Horne, Dave Brubeck and Frank Sinatra. His travels have taken him from South America to the Far East and his motion picture credits include "The Last of the Blue Devils" with Count Basie, the Australian Jazz Festival with Dave Brubeck, as well as T.V. appearances on the Tonight Show and CBS' 60 Minutes.

Butch was interviewed at the Paradise Valley Jazz Party in Scottsdale, Arizona on March 4, 1995 by Dr. Michael Woods and Monk Rowe.

MR: We are here as part of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and we have with us one of the finest drummers in the country, Butch Miles. We just finished a burning set with the Paradise Valley Jazz Party musicians, and welcome.

BM: Thank you, it's very nice to be here.

MR: My first question is how much weight do you lose every night after a set like that?

BM: Well it varies. Some nights I may lose a half a pound. I remember many years ago though, when we were in France we were playing the Grand Parade du Jazz in Nice and I was with the Count Basie band and for some reason I weighed myself on a set of scales in my room before we went out. We played two sets that night, outside, it was in July. When I got back to the room I stepped on the scales again for some strange reason and I dropped eleven pounds. It was just all water weight. But you could be sure that I was pouring liquid down my throat the rest of the evening.

MR: You have to have two sets of clothes for before the gig and after the gig.

BM: No I usually, if I work real hard, I might drop 3-4 pounds in an evening. It's like I like to tell people that I'm from the Gene Krupa, Buddy Rich, Louis Bellson school of drumming, but I'm from the Elvin Jones school of perspiration, cause I do sweat a lot.

MR: That's saying something. Were you a typical bang-on-the-pots-and-pans-in-the-kitchen little kid?

BM: Well kind of. Not so much the pots and pans. I did bang on everything else around the house, and when I was nine years old I talked my mother into buying my first drum. It was an old medium Ludwig parade drum. For those of you who are going to be watching this overseas, it was medium Ludwig. I used to march up and down the street and just bang on that. Then a few years later, after I'd gone through a number of school bands,

and became very fascinated and enamored with a drum set. I talked her into buying me one of those too. Of course after that I had everything set up in the basement in our house. My mother was working all the time, all day. My grandfather and grandmother were living there with us, and my grandfather had a job which got him out of the house. My grandmother was partially deaf, because I was down in the basement. During the summers or school break I'd be down there 6-8 hours a day practicing. Well I didn't know any better.

MR: You didn't know that this wasn't fun?

BM: Oh, I was having a marvelous time, this was great. I practiced everything. I practiced dynamics, I practiced tempos, I practiced various rhythms — Latin rhythms, dance rhythms — and played along with records.

MW: Who were some of the influential drummers that you listened to that you liked at that time?

BM: Well my first big influence was Gene Krupa. He was like the biggest influence on me. Right at the beginning I was a huge fan of Gene's. I loved everything about him. I loved his style and his sound, and his flair, his showmanship, and the way he would really put over a great drum solo — even add that little extra pizzazz that just made me say "Wow." Because a lot of times you see some wonderful musicians and they just look like they can't wait for the next taxi out of town. They're not enjoying themselves or having any good time or communicating a lot that way with an audience. They let the music do all the talking. That's absolutely fine, that's wonderful, but I like to see a little show business thrown in there too. And then I was very big fan of Joe Morello's and Louie Bellson, and a little bit later, Buddy Rich, once I began to understand what he was doing. What he was playing was way above my head. I couldn't understand it. And then I got into Roy Haynes, I loved Papa Jo Jones, Philly Joe Jones, Baby Dodds, Chick Webb, you know the list is pretty endless. There's almost no drummer that I don't admire, living or dead.

MR: From that list it's almost as if you went backwards in first listening to like Krupa and then listening to guys that came even before him.

BM: Um humm, I had a starting point, which was probably the late '30's and I moved on after that into the early to middle '40's and then I really began getting interested in the early '30's and the '20's. And so I was moving in all sorts of directions. I know there are a lot on youngsters today, they'll start with maybe Elvin Jones or Tony Williams, which for them is going back 30 or 35 years. And that's like the beginning of the history of jazz drumming, but you just have to work back further and further. So I started with what I really enjoyed very much, which was Gene Krupa. And like I said, Joe Morello and Louie Bellson and Buddy Rich, and Papa Jo Jones, and was going in different directions

embrace, ultimately, as many of the great, great drummers, far back toward the beginning of this century and on up to somebody I might meet tomorrow afternoon or somebody that I heard play last week. And I love them all.

MR: What was it that attracted you to that kind of music rather than —

BM: I have no idea —

MR: Sandy Nelson and —

BM: Well there's no disrespect to Mr. Nelson, I just couldn't stand his playing (sorry about the towel, it's still dripping, does this come on the microphone, that's all right we'll get it later). I started out on a drum set playing the most banal rock 'n roll, this was in 1959, 1958. And there was really nothing going on in rock 'n roll exciting or creative, not like a lot of the wonderful, wonderful bands you've got now and the great drummers you've got now. It was all pretty cut and dried and very boring. But I was playing in a little rock 'n roll band back in high school and then I joined the musician's union and I started playing with dance bands, little groups around my home town of Charlestown, WV, and maybe it was my mother's influence. She loved the great jazz from the World War II era. She had some very nice records, and I just felt like this is too easy. This rock 'n roll is boom, whack-whack, boom, whack. There's nothing really to it. So I went to the best teacher in town. It wasn't the best teacher I could find it was absolutely THE best teacher in town, a really wonderful, wonderful teacher, great drummer, by the name of Frank Thompson. Frank took me under his wing. He was a fine jazz drummer and immediately turned me in that direction. So I say Frank probably had so much influence on getting me into jazz rather than, I don't know, bluegrass or whatever, which is on T.V. all the time. That was very, pretty terrible too. It wasn't until later on that I understood more about the music and I was able to actually recognize the excellence of some of these bands that I grew up disliking very much. And as I got older I went back and listened to some of these bands and said, well, these bands were great — what was I thinking of? It took me a long time to get into Duke Ellington's music. Basie I was into right from the get go, the second I heard the band, because it just hit me right in my heart, you know, right in the solid something right in here, it just said this is it, boom. Ellington took a little bit longer. And then I happened to see the Duke at a jazz festival at Cincinnati, Ohio. He had the whole band there, Bunny Briggs, the great tap dancer was there, and John Coltrane was supposed to play a set either before or after Duke. Well the sets were only 45 minutes long, and Trane didn't show for some reason. So they asked Duke to play a double set, 90 minutes. And it was some of the fastest 90 minutes I'd ever sat through. By the time they were finished I could not believe an hour and a half had already gone. I was enthralled. So I loved Duke's music. And from there on I started trying to check other big bands out,

and that got me further and I should say deeper and deeper into that style era of the '30's, and the '40's and the '50's.

MW: So you played some with the Basie band?

BM: Four and a half years.

MW: Tell us about that rhythm section, that Kansas City sound. That was different than the east coast or the west coast, that midwest kind of swing.

BM: Oh — where do you start?

MR: Who did you follow into, I mean who was the drummer before you?

BM: Well it's an interesting story. A young man had been hired by Basie by the name of [sounds like] Ray Pirello. And he'd just been with the band a few weeks when he was in a very bad car accident in Chicago and wound up in the hospital. And Basic called me to come fill in, which I did. Originally I think it was one of these week to ten day things, until Ray was better. But his injuries were more extensive than anybody thought. And by the time Ray was well and absolutely fit and ready to go again I'd been with the band about maybe a month and a half or two months, and I was starting to get a little bit of newspaper notice, which never hurts. And so the Basie gave me the job. Now here's the weird thing. Okay, Ray was with the band for a couple of weeks and I jumped in. Then at one point we were playing with Sammy Davis Jr. we were down in Florida, down in Miami Beach, and my dear friend Duffy Jackson was working with Sammy. Then, after I left the Basie band, Duffy joined Basie and Ray went with Sammy. So it was like —

MR: Musical chairs.

BM: Yeah, the same people, and that worked out really good. But the Basie rhythm section, that's one humongous responsibility to think about because, and I love being here with this jazz festival with John Heard because when I was on the band, four and a half years, we had three bass players. They were all named John: it was John Heard, John Duke and John Clayton. And John Heard left the band for a while and John Duke came in. John Duke left the band and John Heard came back. Then John left the band and Clayton came in. So it was so much that Bobby Plater, one of the writers of a wonderful tune musical called "Jersey Bounce," wrote a special solo for John Clayton called John the Third, naturally. But when I first started with the Basie band it was John Duke, myself, and of course Freddie Green, Count Basie. And it was, oh, I can't believe that I didn't actually maybe go slightly insane the first time I sat down to work with the Basie band because the responsibility of the drum chair in that band is enormous. But I was young and foolish and I was scared to death, absolutely just frightened to death, because there was no rehearsal, no tryout. Basie called me on a Tuesday morning, I jumped on a plane and flew to Chicago, somehow got my drums and everything down to the Happy Medium —

location in Chicago — checked into the hotel, had something to eat, met with Mr. Basie, and showed up for work. And that was it. Well you see, one of the wonderful things about something like that is that the leader of the band or the band itself will find out real fast if you can play, and real fast if you can't. You know there's no if. I mean you're not hanging around for six months until someone says "well I don't think he's making it." You know it's phew, it's real quick.

MR: John Heard was telling us that his first night on the thing and he said "what tunes are we playing" and everybody in the band told him a different number, and he had to just like listen and see if he could do it, and apparently he did it.

BM: Well I had an enormous amount of help. Because sitting immediately on my left was the fabulous Al Grey. Have you talked to Al yet?

MR: Yes.

BM: Okay.

MR: We had a great session.

BM: Well he saved me. I'll tell you right out front, Al Grey saved me, because no matter what intro Basie played, Al knew the number of the arrangement and would call out the arrangement. And while Basie is doodling around on the piano, everybody's getting the chart up. And he saved me because of course I didn't know any of the numbers. And there were about six or seven or eight pieces that I had no arrangement on at all, but fortunately I knew things like "Jumpin' at the Woodside," or "April in Paris," "One O'clock Jump," "Whirly Bird," you know, a few of those, "Moten," I never saw arrangements in the book. I don't even know if there'd ever been a drum part written for those. But Al Grey absolutely saved my life every night, for so long, until I learned a lot of the book and I didn't need the music in front of me anymore, when Al would call those numbers out. I don't think he ever got one wrong, either. The memory was just amazing. It was incredible.

MR: Well I can imagine that would be like an un-fun position to be in, like he's playing this intro and you're going, [gasp] now?

BM: Well later it became a very fun position to be in, because I knew all the intros, and I knew most all the tunes except maybe some of the new ones that we'd just recorded the day before, the week before, we were all still scuffling and learning ourselves. But it was great. I could tell within one or two bars what the tune was going to be. But I'd still get them mixed up every once in a while, for some reason, I'd get the drum breaks on "Shiny Stockings" mixed up in my mind with the drum breaks on "Corner Pocket," and I'd play the wrong break. I don't know why, it would happen, I'd have a total lapse, complete lapse of memory, you know and just zoom right in there in the wrong place. But Basie

never gave me a hard time about it. He'd just look at me or give me a face. "I'm sorry, Chief, I get it, I get it."

MR: Was he a good boss?

BM: Oh, he was wonderful, he was wonderful, he just — (if I'd known we were going to do this I would have brought a blue towel, I hope this is in color.) He was a wonderful boss because he never told you what to do or what to play. I asked our road manager, band manager at that time it was Sonny Cohn, and Cup sat right in front of me on the band bus, and after I'd been with the band about maybe two weeks, you know I said, "Sonny, you know, Basie hasn't said anything to me about whether he wants it this way, or he doesn't want it that way," I said, because I'd worked with a number of other people who'd made it quite clear what they wanted and the way that they wanted it. And Basie didn't say a word. And so Cup just looked at me, he says, "well if it's wrong, he'll tell you, and if it's not, he'll just let you go." And that was why he had great professionals in the band who took care of the business so well, because they were professionals. Basie didn't hire somebody that just turned 16 with an incredible reputation but couldn't play. So he — that one time, it was a funny story too. I can't remember if Al was still on the band at that point or not, but we had a trumpet problem and somebody recommended a young trumpet player from Chicago. He flew in to New York, and since we made it pretty much a point to not rehearse, there was no rehearsal again or audition, it was kind of like a closed shop. You got in on recommendation or if Basie had heard you play himself and wanted you to come in with the band. And I can't remember the young man's name but he came in and he was all full of fire and brimstone, he was ready to show the world that he was like the greatest trumpet player in the world, probably like in his early twenties or something, although that doesn't have anything to do with it. And the night of his first gig with the band he made the absolute mistake of thinking that Basie was a real cream puff and he lipped off to him. He said something sassy or nasty, right before the job. I never saw this happen before. Basie fired him, right then.

MR: The guy didn't play a note yet?

BM: Not with the band. Basie fired him, right then, gave him his ticket home and told him good-bye. He never did play a note, not with the band. He came in all hot, you know had his hat over to the side. It didn't work like that. The band was a very well-oiled machine and it was a band, it was a big band, it was a full ensemble. Basie played the band like he played the piano. And it had to work like that. You couldn't have 18 or 19 superstars up there 'cause it never works. So the band was as a unit. And it had to be that way. Oh we had stars. We had Jimmy Forrest, we had Al Grey, we had Curtis Fuller at one point, we had Bobby Plater, Charlie Fowlkes, a great baritone saxophonist, you know, various

anybody that ran roughshod through the band. Basie wouldn't stand for that. He just would not. And I never saw him get mad at anybody in the band except that one time. He was a very affable, easy going, wonderful man and just marvelous to work for, but you didn't sass him, you did not sass him. One time we were playing a theater in LA and we were on stage, a big production thing, Oscar Peterson was there and Ella Fitzgerald and her trio. And so one night, let me see who was it? I think it was Redd Foxx and Billy Eckstine showed up. And Billy got behind a curtain and while we were out on stage and everything and B is right behind the curtain: "Count Basie, Count Basie, now don't you — Count Basie." And Basie put up with this for about a half a chorus or something and the band started burning whatever we were playing. And Basie got up from the piano, in full view of the whole audience, walked over to the side of the stage where Redd and Billy were behind a curtain and proceeded to chew Billy out. He says, "don't you do that while I'm on, I wouldn't do that to you while you're on stage, don't you do that to me." And it turned around and both of them were sorry, like they were just having fun. But I guess they caught Basie at a strange moment.

MR: Interesting. What — have you ever been on a gig when Joe Williams was a guest vocalist?

BM: Oh, yeah, many times, many times. He's wonderful to work with also. As a matter of fact there's another bit of Basie memorabilia is that when I was in the band, the lady who was going to be and is now my wife, she and I decided that we were going to get married in Las Vegas because we were going in to play a stint with Tony Bennett at the Sahara Hotel for one or two weeks. And we all agreed. And her father passed away when she was quite young, and so one of the closest friends we had was Basie, and so she asked him if he would walk her down the aisle. We got married at one of these little wedding chapels in Las Vegas. And he agreed. And then we asked Joe and Jillean Williams to be our seconds. And they agreed. So I can in all honesty say Joe Williams was my best man when I got married. It was wonderful. Sarah Vaughan was there, and just all kinds of people. Yeah, I worked off and on with Joe many times with the band, and of course did all the wonderful stuff, "Every Day," and "Roll 'Em Pete" and "Comeback" and a lot of all the great, great hits that he had with the band. Of course I knew all of them by heart. I didn't need any charts on there. But it was really wonderful.

MR: Who were some of your favorite arrangers for the Basie group?

BM: Oh, for the Basie band?

MR: I mean they had so many great ones.

BM: Well Neal Hefti, Neal Hefti was absolutely wonderful. Frank Foster. Frank Wess wrote a number of things for the band, wonderful. Let me see, John Clayton wrote a few things

other, Sammy Nestico is just one of my all time favorite Basie writers. He's one of my all time favorite writers anyway, he's a great, great arranger, just marvelous. Chico O'Farrill did a number of things for the band that were just great. Unfortunately we never played any of Oliver Nelsen's arrangements when I was in the band. We played a couple of Thad Jones arrangements which were great, they were really wonderful. But there were a lot of the charts from earlier days that I really wanted to play with the band and we never did. For instance I was on the band four and a half years and we played "Cute" one time.

MR: No kidding?

BM: Yeah, I must have been lousy that night. Because over the years I had my major drum solo was "Whirly Bird," and then we pulled out "Summertime" which was an Eric Dixon arrangement as I recall. It was a very fine arrangement. And then Dennis Wilson, who was playing trombone at the time, was playing some fine charts for the band too and he wrote a thing called "Good Mileage" which was a big drum feature for me. But one night Basie called "Cute." I don't know where that came from but we played it one time. Another one, out of the four and a half years that we played that I just loved was a Frank Foster chart on "Blues in Hoss Flat," we played that one time.

MR: Four years to pull it out one time.

BM: Well at least I got to play it once, with the band.

MR: Since the Basie band, what have been some of your favorite moments?

BM: Oh, gee, it's a lot of them, I've got to tell you, because I left the band 16 years ago, in 1979. I hadn't thought about that. But since then I've gone and traveled all over the world, I've worked with a lot of great different people. It was funny I never had a chance to work with Sweets Edison until after I left the band, you know, and then I started from time to time working with ex-Basieites, we kind of like would conglomerate and get together, Clark Terry, the magnificent Red Holloway, I was with Dave Brubeck part of a year, and just had such a wonderful time with his quartet. As a matter of fact when I left the Basie band I went right with the Brubeck quartet.

MW: Can I ask you a question? Did you play a show with Dave Brubeck in Tulsa, Oklahoma —

BM: Sure did.

MW: At the Brady Theater? I played in the orchestra behind you.

BM: Oh really!

MW: The Brady Street Orchestra and [sounds like] Barry Epperly was the conductor. I remember that night 'cause I was impressed with your playing.

BM: Oh, thank you.

MW: One of my drum students, Tom Harden, who was in the percussion section said, "man

BM: Well I used to do a, thank you very much, I used to do a number of things, I tried to be original, with Brubeck, but as you know, every single night we would sooner or later we'd have to close with "Take Five." They just would not let him out of town without playing "Take Five," and so that was my big moment and I used to do small little pockets of tributes to Joe Morello, and throw some of those in there.

MR: I wonder, I always wondered how Brubeck felt about that, that he was such a writer but the band's biggest hit, you know, he didn't write.

BM: Yeah, I know, Paul Desmond. There's two stories about that, one that I heard and I've never even actually asked Dave this, although Dave I think told somebody that Desmond had written that. But somebody else, and this hearsay, absolute hearsay, but somebody else said that Dave had actually written "Take Five" but he put Paul's name on it. Now I don't know. But knowing probably, well knowing how Dave is, the version that he tells is the correct one, so I'm sure that Desmond wrote it. But he was a great guy. I had no trouble switching formats from the roaring Basie straight ahead big style to the quartet, because the quartet was roaring also. It was a very strong quartet. Jerry Bergonzi was on tenor sax at the time, and Chris Brubeck was on bass and also bass trombone, and it could zoom right along great. But I had no problem with the odd time signatures because that was something else that I used to practice down in that basement, when my mother and grandfather were at work all day and driving people crazy. I drove people so crazy that actually the people across the street from us put their house up on the market and moved. Boy I must be a big band drummer, I'm loud.

MR: There goes the neighborhood.

BM: Yeah, it sure did. But working with Brubeck and the whole Brubeck clan was just absolutely delightful. And then, after that, it's been very notable. I've worked off and on for a few years with Lena Horne, who is one of my favorite all-time people in the world, not only just as an entertainer, but as a person, I love her. I've worked with Gerry Mulligan off and on for a couple of years, fascinating experience, I really dig Gerry. You know we've been good, close friends for a number of years and he was always remarkable to work with because you never knew what he was going to do. Same with Lena. You could rehearse the heck out of something, I mean have it down like this, and you get on stage and it's no, no, no, we're going to change that, we're going to change this, let's throw this over here, let's do a stop time, then no, I want a little faster, no a little slower. You know all of a sudden it was well what were we spending all those days rehearsing for? Now we're changing things. But that's part of jazz, that's part of jazz. That's one thing that Basie did not do a great deal of was change things. Once that arrangement was settled the way it was, it stayed settled. The solos would change, I mean

your statement, it's quick. And once again it was the machine, it had to be like that. Otherwise you could have 18 anarchists up there on stage.

MR: You know, a couple people today said the same thing about the Basie band and that was its ability to swing like crazy at a soft tempo. And that's got to be one of the hardest things to do — to really have energy but be playing so quiet.

BM: Well you have to keep the energy level very high, even when you're playing softly, because otherwise if the level of energy comes down then a lot of times maybe the volume would come down even further, and the tempo might drop. But one of the trademarks I learned early on with the Basie band was that they had such a remarkable range and versatility in dynamics. I mean the Basie band didn't just play piano, mezzopiano, mezzoforte, forte fortissimo. When you played soft you played soft. And then when you came in loud, BOOM, it was like a bomb going off and then you dropped back down to nothing. You know the band loved that. And one of the great arrangements was "All of Me," where Basie takes like the whole first half of the tune and then goes into right before the bridge the band explodes, and then drops back down to nothing again, completely, in just a split second. And it's not done with mirrors, and it's definitely not done with sound technicians with a board and all these cats from rock 'n roll city with all the dials and everything saying "well I think I'll make it loud now, go on now." We did it all naturally, au natural. Because the band, we had three microphones, generally, unless we were playing like some huge stadium with thirty or forty thousand people. Three microphones. There were two down front for the soloists, and one for the Chief to speak on. Now if we were doing a television or radio show, naturally that was different, everything was miced to the hilt. But in regular concert, just three microphones. And Basie didn't like to have the piano miced. He liked playing it soft because people would start to listen like that and then when the band would come in you'd have that diversity of dynamics again.

MR: Right, so you had to play to the level of that piano, unmiced piano.

BM: I had to be able to hear him. That's one thing Joe Williams told me one time, just what you're saying, is that you know he said, "if you're back here playing and he's out there playing, and you can't hear what he's playing, you're too loud." I said, "well Joe, how about a monitor?" He said, "no you're too loud, you can't hear him. Even if he's 10 or 15 feet away, you're too loud." And that really stuck with me, especially since the Basie days and during the Basie days. But it was a great lesson to learn.

MW: You know I was going to say I think you are giving some tremendous lessons here to a lot of younger musicians who just want to play loud and fast.

BM: Oh well there are a lot of younger who can play loud and fast, they play faster than me

go. And how do you say that musically, if you start off loud and fast, that's it. What are you going to do after that? You just play loud and fast. So what? You know so there are a thousand drummers out there right now, 10, 15, 20 years younger than I am, can play twice as loud and three times faster. But does it swing? You know it doesn't make musical sense. That was another thing that Basie taught. Boy he would set some of those tempos we used to call right in the pocket, right in the slot. And it felt like it should be just a little faster, or just a little slower, but it wasn't, it was right in there. And, oh, thank the Lord for Freddie Green. Freddie Green was just boom, Mr. Seth Thomas Metronome back there, and he was just — now he was an education in himself. Of course Freddie built the band and I think when Freddie passed away he'd been with the band like 50 or 55 something like that. But the band would never have been, I feel, the Basie band, without Freddie. You know I mean when Basie was still alive. It was such an integral part of the band and even when he played, I mean he played unamplified guitar.

MR: Right, it's almost like you couldn't, you didn't hear it unless it was like stopped and then it would be, oh, what happened.

BM: Yeah, if he wasn't playing, you sure missed it, but it added so much to the band and to the Basie sound. There were a lot of amazing things about the Basie sound that were very difficult. No other band has ever sounded quite like that. It's like no other band ever really sounded like Duke's band either. There were a lot of things where maybe the entire reed section in ensemble would play behind the beat. All five of them would play behind the beat and when we'd come back they'd come in together. Or the brass might have a quarter note triplet and on one particular arrangement it would be perfectly in time and on another arrangement they'd lay back on it. Or things like that. Or they'd clip a note, where sometimes you might figure a horn player would play the full value, they might clip it because that was the way that they were interpreting. And Bobby Plater came up to me one time we were playing — oh darn — I think it was "Moten Swing" I'm trying to remember if that is the arrangement. Now see I'm getting these arrangements mixed up in my head. But there's a sax ensemble in the middle of one of those charts which is just amazing, incredible. And they would start off smack on the beat and then by the time they were into the first or second bar they were behind, they were phrasing behind, but all five of them were phrasing together. And boy the first few months I was on the band I wasn't used to that. You see I was always used to this, it had to be played this way. That was the way I thought, I had very, like tunnel vision, where tempos went. And Bobby finally came to me one day and says, "listen, when we get to that section, don't listen to us. Lock in to the rhythm section, and get that section strong, and let us do what we're going to do 'cause we're going to rely on you. If you start listening to us the whole thing

in right, we'll get out just in time." But this was a Basie trademark, and I had to take that advice and burn it into my memory. He was absolutely correct.

MW: Did you find that other bands either didn't have that flexibility or were afraid to let sections of the band fall back like that?

BM: You know that's a very good question, because first of all I never heard a band other than Basie that could do that. And I've heard bands that tried, but they didn't do it right. Maybe it was the combination of a specific Basie sound that had been borne over so many years and plus playing it so many times. I mean we must have played, in four and a half years "Jumpin' at the Woodside" in four and a half years there were certain things you just could not get away from, you had to play. Of course "April in Paris" was a great deal, and always "One O'clock Jump." It got to the point where you could play that totally sound asleep in a coma, you know, with a religious person standing over you saying this is it, you're going to die, but first the outchorus to "One O'clock Jump." Just go through the whole bit. It got to be like that, you sort of, we were on the road in such close proximity to each other all the time that so many of us began to think alike on the stage as far as the ensemble and the Basie arrangements went. There were, let me see there was 18 guys in the band, a vocalist, 19, and our band equipment manager. We used to call it the band boy but you don't say that anymore. So that was like 20 people, then a bus driver, but we never knew who the bus driver was because we didn't have a regular bus. Basie leased or chartered from Greyhound most the time. So we had different cats who were driving and whatnot going around. But you might start off the day by getting up at 6:00 in the morning to leave the hotel at 7:00 in the morning to make a 9:00 flight. So you've got to drive over to where the airport is, you know, everybody on the bus. Then you have everybody sitting around the airport. Then you get on the plane and you fly somewhere, everybody's on the plane. Then you get off the plane and many times you'd have to get back on the bus and travel two or three hours to the destination. Then everybody goes in and gets something to eat. Then you show up, then you do the show, then more often than not you pack up and if you were lucky enough to have a hotel then you'd go back to the hotel and sometimes we'd get back on the bus and drive all night. You could make what we called the day sheet. If you drove all night, because we all paid our rooms and food, meals and all those expenses. Basie paid transportation. And if you could skip the hotel or the motel for that evening and driving all night until you get into the next town 6:30 or 7:00 in the morning, then the day sheet changes and they'll charge you for that day. If you get in there at 1:30 in the morning, they'll charge you for that day, and the next day. You know sort of like 1:30 in the morning is still the day before, even though it's after midnight, so they change that day sheet at 6, 6:30. And many times

pennies and we'd do what's called a hit and run. You'd hit the town that you were going in and then back on the bus and run to the next town. We had a lot of fun that way though. Yeah, we did.

MR: Some endurance.

BM: Yeah. But you know I've said this all my life. Four and a half years — blizzards, rain storms, getting lost, yeah we got lost all the time, the bus drivers didn't know where to go and we couldn't tell them, that's what we hired him, Basie hired him for, to get us there. And getting to places that we really didn't want to be, sometimes no food, sometimes no overcoat, just a whole bunch of stuff I never ever, ever heard the band sound bad. Never. Four and a half years of one-nighters. They always sounded good. Many nights they were great, and some nights they were just unbelievable. And you never could figure that out. A lot of times you'd have four or five guys down with the flu. And everybody's tired and they haven't had a chance to shave and you're all kind of crummy and stuff like that. The band would roar. Just incredible. Then there were some nights where everything was fine, the guys were rested, it was a beautiful job the whole bit, and the band was good, it wasn't bad, but it wasn't like that other night. You could always tell the difference. Maybe I'm not on, or somebody didn't make the note or something doesn't sound right or the rhythm section isn't really locking in for some reason. You know, I'm not locking in with Freddie and John, whichever John it might be. And there were just some nights like that. But the band always sounded good. It was such a pleasure. You know I'm going to have to get out of here —

MR: Just a word about this phenomenon of these jazz festivals, these jazz parties, it's like a great thing for musicians.

BM: It is a great thing. This one's been going on here in Scottsdale for sixteen or eighteen years. Some of them have dropped by the wayside unfortunately. There were so many of them just a few years ago, let's say about five, ten years ago there were so many jazz parties all around the country, that a lot of people who wanted to go and hear this one, then wanted to go and hear that one, then wanted to go and hear that one, they couldn't afford it or some of the parties would overlap and the producers, the promoters wouldn't work with the other producers and promoters to see if we could all come to some sort of nice agreement as to when you're going to have yours: "well, last year I had it at this time, I'm not going to change it just because so-and-so's having one at the same time." And a few have passed away. Gibson's jazz party, he's the granddaddy of jazz parties, he invented the jazz party. That one is rumored to maybe starting back up again you never know. Dick started the whole thing I think it was in Aspen, and then moved it on down to Colorado Springs, and in later years up to Denver. And that hasn't been happening for a

And then there's a couple of other parties around the country that have hung on for 10 or 15 years and struggled as hard as they could and have done well but then finally just said no, we just can't do any more, we have to cancel, you know for whatever reason. But thank God there's still a number of these wonderful parties around the country that we get a chance to play at. And I get a chance to I think maybe if you ask some of the other guys they'll tell you the same thing, we get a chance to see each other every once in a while. You know sometimes you may not see some of these guys for two or three or five years, and then you have a chance for a couple of days to get back together and play and enjoy your company and tell lies, and all kinds of stuff like that. So it's a lot of fun though.

MW: Real quick. Are there any other venues on the way up for the young lions? Places for them to play, things for them to do, that authenticates the music and makes the music one with the culture. And if so, if not, what can be instituted?

BM: Well that is a good one. There are different ways of getting your education, your musical education from the way I did starting out playing just in dance groups and dance bands and after-hour joints where you play a club that you couldn't buy liquor by the drink it was illegal and you'd have to go and then everybody would fall by at midnight, 1:00 in the morning, 2:00 and jam sessions. But there's a lot of different opportunities out now for a lot of the like you say "young lions." Some of these jazz parties. Some of the jazz promoters. You hear some of these people but say this guy is really great but nobody knows who he is, I want to have him, or her for my party, bring them out. Other people get a chance to hear them. Some of the promoters like George Wein and others. George is still involved naturally with the JVC jazz festival in New York and he does some scouting around the country and hears a lot of people, loves to hire some of these guys like Nicholas Payton, fantastic young trumpet player out of New Orleans, you know or Wallace Roney or some of these other people, and bring them out and give them exposure. There's different places to play, especially in the European market. We do a lot of traveling overseas. I was over in Europe last year, I think four times, four or five times I can't recall. This year I'll be in Europe two, maybe three times, and in Japan also. So there is some hope out there. They still have a lot of clubs. A lot of the nightclubs and entertainment areas around the United States have just gotten too expensive, people can't afford it, the overhead is very high where these people are going to play. But Buddy Rich said it one time. Years ago someone asked him, said, "Buddy, we've got so many of these wonderful players coming out of the colleges and universities, where are they going to play? The clubs are all drying up and nothing's happening. What are they going to do?" And Buddy said, "the cream always rises to the top." I've run into a lot of people who've

and then I graduated from college and I got married and I got the job and boy I sure am sorry I stopped." I say, "I'm sorry you stopped, too, but don't bitch to me about your stopping." "I got out of college, I got a job, I got a family, so that's why I had to quit playing." "Oh, no, you don't have to quit playing." You see a whole lot of people out there who didn't quit playing either. So you just — and it is tough, it is tough. You have to stick in this business, 'cause it will kill you, it will just waste you away and then turn around and make your life so marvelous you can't believe you ever thought of a rainy day as everything is sunshine and beautiful blue skies. And then maybe the next day you're back with clouds and thunderstorms. I'm just using a weather analogy.

MR: Well it does have its highs and lows.

BM: It's just like life. But you really have to I think if you want it bad enough, you've got to stick with it very very deeply. I stuck with it long enough. See I didn't join the Basie band until I was 30. And I'm 50 now and it was incredible. Everybody says, "wow you were a young kid when you were with Basie." I say, "No, I wasn't a young kid, I just, I had a young face, and I weight about ten pounds less than I do now and I dyed my hair." Because we had one of those things, my hair bleached out about the second or third month I was on the band and I started getting some press, a newspaper thing about the young, blonde, white drummer with the Basie band. I said, "AHA — young BLONDE white drummer," I can use this. So, you know for years Loreal and Clairol were good friends of mine. And it worked, I was the young, blonde, white drummer, instead of the young, white drummer. So that worked along too. But I stuck with it for, well let me say I've been playing now professionally, it's pretty young compared to some of these great giants in there. I've got my first musician's union card 35 years ago. And I started playing on a drum six years before that. So I've been playing 41 years, or had something to do with drums for 41 years. And like I said, when I went with the Basie band I was already 30 years old. And sometimes that's a little late. You know people think well if I haven't made it by the time I'm 30 I'm just going to give it up. I never thought about quitting. Never ever thought about that. I thought about killing myself. But I never thought about quitting. Well, you know, sometimes you just say — but I never ever once said I'm going to give it up.

MR: Well we're glad you didn't.

BM: Well thank you, and thanks for having me over here.

MR: We appreciate your time and you've got to go back to work, right?

BM: Like I said, I gotta get outta here. Well thanks a lot.

MR: Thank you very much.

MW: All right.